

Family Guide: Supporting a Loved One with Schizophrenia

Practical guidance for families and caregivers supporting a loved one with schizophrenia.

Understanding Schizophrenia

A chronic psychotic disorder involving hallucinations, delusions, disorganized thinking, reduced emotional expression, and cognitive difficulties that affect daily functioning.

How to Help a Family Member with Schizophrenia

- Understand it as a chronic, manageable brain disorder: See schizophrenia as an ongoing medical condition requiring management, similar in some ways to a condition like diabetes, rather than a personal failing.
- Practice calm, low-criticism communication: Reducing 'expressed emotion' — high criticism, hostility, or over-involvement — measurably lowers relapse risk compared to a highly critical family environment.
- Support medication adherence without confrontation: Encourage consistent treatment gently and collaboratively rather than through pressure or arguments.
- Respond carefully to delusional beliefs: Avoid directly arguing with delusional beliefs, while also not reinforcing them — acknowledge the person's distress without agreeing with the content.
- Watch for early warning signs of relapse: Learn the person's individual early warning signs, and seek prompt follow-up care if they appear.
- Seek your own support as a caregiver: Caring for a family member with schizophrenia is demanding. Build your own support network and take time for respite.

Taking care of yourself as a caregiver

 [Call Now](#)

 [WhatsApp](#)

counselling if you're feeling overwhelmed — you can't pour from an empty cup.

When to seek urgent help

Seek emergency psychiatric care for an acute psychotic crisis with risk to self or others, command hallucinations instructing self-harm or harm to others, catatonia, severe self-neglect, or any suicidal ideation, which carries an elevated risk especially early in the illness course. A first episode of psychosis warrants prompt specialized assessment, since early treatment substantially improves long-term outcomes.

This material is for patient and family education only and does not replace individualized medical advice. For a personal diagnosis or treatment plan, consult Dr. Kushal Kharel or a qualified mental health professional.

Dr. Kushal Kharel, MD Psychiatry — Consultant Psychiatrist, Kathmandu, Nepal

Phone: +977 9861800547 · drkushalkharel@gmail.com · drkushalkharel.com.np

 **Call Now**

 **WhatsApp**